The Chinese Exclusion Act

47th Congress · May 6, 1882

Source: Chinese Exclusion Act (1882). Public domain. Continuous passage.

> The first federal law to bar an entire nationality, the act suspended Chinese labor immigration for ten years and forbade Chinese immigrants from becoming citizens — a landmark of Gilded Age nativism that shaped U.S. immigration policy for decades.

Whereas, in the opinion of the Government of the United States the coming of Chinese laborers to this country endangers the good order of certain localities within the territory thereof: Therefore, Be it enacted . . . That from and after the expiration of ninety days next after the passage of this act, and until the expiration of ten years next after the passage of this act, the coming of Chinese laborers to the United States be, and the same is hereby, suspended; and during such suspension it shall not be lawful for any Chinese laborer to come, or, having so come after the expiration of said ninety days, to remain within the United States.

[. . .]

SEC. 14. That hereafter no State court or court of the United States shall admit Chinese to citizenship; and all laws in conflict with this act are hereby repealed. SEC. 15. That the words “Chinese laborers”, whenever used in this act, shall be construed to mean both skilled and unskilled laborers and Chinese employed in mining.